urged Johnson to help stabilize Gandhi's position and enable her to undertake further reform. Most officials agreed, and Johnson subsequently approved the US commitment to the India aid consortium to give Gandhi something to show for her efforts.[82] The domestic political damage to her, however, had already been done.

Gandhi tried to explain that devaluation was essential for the country.[83] The whole situation, however, forced her to be much more aware of the need to appear to resist external pressure. As Gandhi told Johnson, the "slightest suspicion of external pressure, whether from foreign countries or international institutions," resulted in domestic political upheaval.[84] She came to see a political imperative in limiting the dependence that India's strategic imperatives required. Gandhi also saw the need to demonstrate that her portfolio of partners remained diversified. American assistance was useful, but appearing to tilt too far toward it (and away from Moscow) held danger for her political survival and her freedom of action at home.[85]

Vietnam: Force or Diplomacy?

The need to correct the appearance of imbalance led Gandhi to a move that would exacerbate difficulties in the US-India relationship. In early July there were calls on Gandhi to speak out on Vietnam after the American bombings of oil installations in Hanoi and Haiphong. Her critics, who had been accusing her of moving away from socialism and nonalignment for aid from the US, pointed to her silence on Vietnam as further evidence of this shift.[86] Initially Gandhi said, "What can we do?" Subsequently, she proposed the immediate convening of a second Geneva conference, but did not suggest the cessation of bombing as a precondition. As a news report commented, she was "careful to spread the blame for the war as evenly as possible." Her call for the withdrawal of "all foreign forces" was indeed seen in Washington as an improvement on a previous Indian call just for the withdrawal of American forces from Vietnam.[87] Beijing saw her statement as biased and rejected the call.[88] At home, it gave her critics further ammunition.

Just a few days later, on a visit to the Soviet Union, there was a volte-face. Gandhi asserted that an American bombing cessation was a precondition for a conference. The India-Soviet communiqué also called for an immediate cessation.[89] Furthermore, at a joint event at which she was